

GOVERNMENT HACK™

Teacher Graphic Organizer Toolkit

Unit 1 — Foundations of Constitutional Government · Reproducible

WHY THIS TOOLKIT

Knowing WHICH organizer to use, and WHEN, is half the battle. This toolkit tells you — with a brief why for each — then gives you reproducible blanks (Part 1) and Unit 1 ready-to-print, pre-labeled organizers (Part 2). Tennessee connections are highlighted throughout; the local-to-national move is a HistoryHack signature and a point of difference for our classrooms.

Which Organizer, When — Quick Guide

Scan the left column for what the activity asks students to do; reach for the organizer on the right. Every organizer in Part 1 also carries its own “when to use · why it works” note.

When the task asks students to...	Reach for...	Why it works
compare / contrast TWO things	Venn (2) or T-Chart	Marzano’s highest-yield strategy; the overlap names shared traits
compare 3+ things on set criteria	Compare & Contrast Matrix	systematic; lowers cognitive load
explain causes / effects	Cause & Effect	makes causal chains visible (SSP.05)
put events in order / show change	Timeline / Sequence	builds chronological reasoning (SSP.05)
brainstorm or connect ideas	Concept Web	activates prior knowledge; shows relationships
summarize a text or source	Main Idea & Details	separates the central idea from support
activate prior knowledge & track learning	KWL	metacognition; frames inquiry
learn a key term deeply	Frayar	deep vocabulary processing
analyze a primary source	HIPPO / OPTIC	disciplinary sourcing (SSP.01-02)
make and defend a claim	CER	claim + evidence + reasoning (SSP.04)
weigh two sides / a decision	T-Chart or Problem-Solution	structures evaluation
capture the basics of an event	5 Ws	ensures full coverage
connect a national event to Tennessee	★ Tennessee Connection	our signature local-to-national move

Reproducible — you may copy these pages for classroom use.

Part 1 — Reusable Blank Organizers (all subjects, all units)

Content-agnostic blanks. Print as many as you need; use across any standard or subject.

Task says “compare,” “contrast,” “how are they alike/different?” for TWO things. Marzano’s #1 strategy (identifying similarities & differences). The shared column forces students to name what overlaps, not just list traits.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL

response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Venn (3) / Triple T-Chart — Compare THREE

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

Comparing three people, groups, or ideas. Use the columns for each item and note shared traits in your notes.

Item A	Item B	Item C
Trait / criterion 1		
Trait / criterion 2		
Trait / criterion 3		
Trait / criterion 4		

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Two categories to sort or weigh: benefits vs costs, pros vs cons, before vs after, cause vs effect. Fast, low-floor entry point for comparison.

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would change if one factor were different?"

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: "_____ because _____, which shows _____."

Compare & Contrast Matrix — Items × Criteria

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

Comparing several items across the SAME set of criteria. Reduces cognitive load by making the comparison systematic.

Criterion	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3

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Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Task asks “what caused...?”, “what were the effects/consequences of...?” Makes causal reasoning visible (builds SSP.05).

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Ordering events or tracing change over time. Builds chronological reasoning (SSP.05).

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Activating prior knowledge or showing how ideas relate to a central concept. Great as a pre-reading or review move.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

5 Ws — Cover the Basics of an Event

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

Making sure students capture who/what/when/where/why of an event before analysis.

Question	Answer
Who?	
What?	
When?	
Where?	
Why?	

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Analyzing a problem and the responses to it (e.g., a policy or reform). Structures evaluation.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Frayer Model — Deep Vocabulary

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

Learning a key term deeply (definition, characteristics, examples, non-examples).

Definition (own words)	Characteristics
Examples	Non-examples

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

CER — Build an Argument

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

Any “make a claim / defend / argue” task. Claim + two pieces of evidence + reasoning (builds SSP.04).

Part	Write here
Claim	
Evidence (two specifics)	
Reasoning	

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

HIPPO — Analyze a Primary Source

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

Analyzing a photo, cartoon, map, or document (builds SSP.01–SSP.02). Pair with OPTIC for visuals.

H-I-P-P-O	Prompt / notes
H — Historical context	
I — Intended audience	
P — Purpose	
P — Point of view	
O — Outside connection	

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Whenever a standard has a Tennessee tie: link the national event to our state/community and say why the local story matters. This local-to-national move is a HistoryHack signature — use it often.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Part 2 — Unit 1 Ready-to-Use Organizers (pre-labeled, best-fit)

Each is matched to the standard whose task it best fits, with a short note on why. Tennessee connections are flagged.

This standard weighs the ratification debate. A T-chart makes the two positions explicit: Federalists favored a stronger union; Anti-Federalists feared central power and demanded a Bill of Rights.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

★ **TENNESSEE CONNECTION**

Tennessee entered the Union in 1796; its state constitution echoes the same separation of powers and Bill of Rights framed in this unit.

GC.03 — Weaknesses of the Articles of Confederation (Cause & Effect)

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

The Articles created a weak national government. A cause -> effect flow shows how each weakness led to a problem: no taxing power -> unpaid debts; no army -> Shays's Rebellion went unchecked.

Cause	→	Effect
	→	
	→	
	→	
	→	

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

The founding is a sequence of documents. A timeline makes the chronology clear: Declaration of Independence (1776) -> Articles of Confederation (1781) -> Constitutional Convention (1787) -> Constitution ratified (1788) -> Bill of Rights (1791).

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

GC.06 — Principles of Limited Government (Matrix)

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

The standard names the principles that limit government. A matrix compares each across the same criteria.

Principle	What it does	Example
Separation of powers		
Checks and balances		
Federalism		
Judicial review		
Popular sovereignty		
Rule of law		

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

GC.09 – Republic vs. Direct Democracy (T-Chart)

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

The standard asks students to distinguish two systems. A T-chart makes the contrast explicit.

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What

would change if one factor were different?"

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: "_____ because _____, which shows _____."

GC.08 — The Bill of Rights (Matrix)

WHEN TO USE · WHY IT WORKS

The standard analyzes how the first amendments limit government. A matrix pairs each amendment with what it protects and an example.

Amendment	What it protects	Example / limit on government
1st		
2nd		
4th		
5th		
10th		

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

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Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

The standard compares the two frameworks. A Venn captures what changed, what stayed, and what both shared.

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL · MTSS)

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”